ArchiveHub Update 1: Build Specification

Nov 10, 2026 · @Adam

Summary

This update makes ArchiveHub about understanding lives, not just collecting records, and its headline feature is the **Lifeline view**: every relative as a bar through time, linked to a map, with events you can switch on and off. It adds to the version 1 specification and doesn't replace it. Where the two disagree, this update wins.

What's new

1. **Lifeline view and migration map:** the main way to explore a family through time. Build this first.
2. **Life Story pages:** each person's jobs, homes, children and events, told in order.
3. **Explain this record:** what a record says, what it meant and where to find out more.
4. **Better tree tools:** galleries, safer merging, bulk building, health checks and safe deletion.
5. **Imports:** bring trees and photos home from Ancestry, MyHeritage, Findmypast and FamilySearch.
6. **Life and times panel:** prices, wages, weather, maps and contemporary accounts for any date or place.
7. **Non-family lineages:** pubs, houses, roles, groups and objects passing from one holder to the next.
8. **Record ordering service:** get paid records through ArchiveHub, where providers allow it.
9. **Wider sources:** a much larger list of databases, archives and repos to connect or learn from.
10. **Life Report and culture links:** one button writes an illustrated life story, with art, poems, ballads and folk tales from the person's world.

Where it came from: your own ideas, plus feedback from your sister, a heavy user of Ancestry and similar sites, and research on sources and repos. This revision also adds the one-button Life Report, with links to art, literature, ballads and folklore, plus their sources.

Headline feature: the Lifeline view

The Lifeline view shows each relative as a bar from birth to death, with a year slider that reveals who was alive at any moment, a linked map, and event layers you can switch on and off. It should be one of the main ways people explore their data, alongside chat, and

the first new feature built.

What it answers

- Who was alive when I was born, for example in 1985?
- Who lived through both World Wars, or was young during one?
- Which relatives overlapped, and could they have known each other?
- Where was everyone living in a given year, and who moved?

Requirements

Area	Requirement
Rows	One bar per person, from 10 to several hundred people, with smooth scrolling
Year slider	A vertical line the user drags through time. People alive at that point are highlighted, and recent deaths and soon-to-be births are marked differently
Alive count	A small chart above the timeline showing how many relatives were alive each year
Event layers	Overlays for wars, laws, local events, family events and personal markers like a birth year
Toggles	Switch each type of event on or off, and add custom markers
Grouping and filters	By branch, generation, surname, place or direct line
Linked map	The map shows where living relatives were in the chosen year, with migration paths
Autoplay	Play forward or backward through time at an adjustable speed
Uncertain dates	Fade or blur bar ends for approximate dates, and show "about" or "before" in labels
Living people	Hide or anonymise living relatives on anything shared
Links	Clicking a bar opens Life Story, and clicking an event opens its explanation

Area	Requirement
Chat control	Commands like "show who was alive in 1985" or "highlight both World Wars"
Export	A printable timeline poster and an image for sharing
Phone	Swipe through years, with bars stacked and the map one tap away

Acceptance tests

1. A 200-person sample tree renders and scrolls smoothly on a mid-range laptop.
2. Setting the slider to 1985 lists exactly those whose records place them alive then, with uncertain cases labelled.
3. Turning off "wars" removes only war overlays.
4. A person with an estimated birth year shows a faded start, not a sharp one.
5. Moving the slider updates the map without a full reload.
6. A shared export contains no details of living people unless the owner allows it.

Repos to learn from

- Time Travel Map: timeline slider, alive-count chart and autoplay. GPL-3.0, so study it and don't copy it.
- Kinwhere: GEDCOM to ancestry map and migration view. MIT.
- Family Plot: people positioned by birth year in 3D. GPL-3.0.
- SVG Timeline Genealogy: genealogy timelines in SVG. No licence found.

Record improvements

These changes answer the frustrations of a heavy Ancestry user: records that don't tell a story, clumsy photos, bad merges and messy trees. The aim is a tree that feels like real people's lives.

Feature	What it does	Done when
Life Story page	Each person's life in order: jobs, homes, marriages, children and key events, with context kept separate	A person with 10+ records reads as a clear life, not a list of documents

Feature	What it does	Done when
Person gallery	A scrollable gallery of every photo and document image for that person	Photos can be added, tagged and reordered in seconds
Family gallery	Gatherings and group photos, tagged to several people at once	One photo appears in each tagged person's gallery
Snippets	Short excerpts from records and articles, with the full source a click away	Every snippet links to its source and evidence label
Consistent source cards	One clean style for every record, whatever site it came from	Users don't need to work out which site a record came from
Merge preview	Shows exactly what a suggested match would add before accepting	Users can accept some facts and reject others
Bulk tree building	Adds a whole suggested branch in one step, if the user approves it	One undo removes the whole branch
Explained suggestions	Says why a match is suggested, with sources and conflicts	No suggestion relies only on "other trees say so"
Tree health check	Finds duplicates, broken links, unlikely dates and unsourced people	Runs after every import and on request
Safe deletion	Shows which people and branches a delete would strand	Offers to reconnect, keep or remove them

Importing from other sites

Trees can be brought home as GEDCOM files, but photos usually need a separate step.

Site	Export route	What's missing
Ancestry	The tree owner downloads a GEDCOM	Photos and media, and outside services are blocked from downloading them
MyHeritage	GEDCOM export from Manage Trees	Photo files, though links can be included

Site	Export route	What's missing
Findmypast	GEDCOM export from the tree page	Contents not documented
FamilySearch	Through listed apps only, up to eight generations in GEDCOM 7	Photos, and spouses other than the "preferred" one

Import flow

1. Upload a GEDCOM, including GEDCOM 7.
2. Run the tree health check.
3. Preview what will be added or merged.
4. Upload a photo folder, and the assistant suggests which person each photo belongs to.
5. Keep each source tree's IDs, so a later re-import updates people without creating duplicates.

Rules: records a user downloaded stay private in their Archive by default. Never bulk-download other sites. Check whether desktop software like Family Tree Maker or RootsMagic can help users export media, and whether UK GDPR data portability applies.

First real test: import your sister's exported tree and check the duplicates and broken links she described.

Explain this record

Every record should come with an explanation of what it meant for the person who lived it, because the meaning is often buried in an archive. It came from a family example: two brothers recorded in a Swindon institution, which only made sense after a visit to an archive revealed it took in children whose parents couldn't care for them.

Layer	What it shows	Example
What it says	The record in its original wording	Names, date and institution
What the words mean	Institutions, old terms, jobs and legal language	What the institution was and what "admitted" meant then
What it may mean for them	A careful interpretation, labelled as such	Their mother may have been unable to care for them
Where to find out more	Records to look for, the likely archive and what to ask there	Admission papers and army records

Requirements

- **Local knowledge base:** institutions, old occupations, legal terms, regiments, Poor Law practices and local record types, each with sources.
- **Place and institution pages:** for example, a page for each workhouse, regiment or factory, linking to the people recorded there, subject to permissions.
- **Expert input:** archivists and historians can write or check explanations, with visible credit and possible payment.
- **Add findings back:** what someone learns at an archive can be added with its source, helping the next family.
- **Sensitive records:** handle workhouses, asylums, illegitimacy and prison records humanely, and let descendants control what's shared.
- **Careful language:** say "families often did this because…" unless there's evidence for "your family did this".

Possible demo: your family's workhouse story, if the family agrees. It needs the institution's name, the dates and what was found at the archive.

Life and times panel

For any person, date or place, a side panel shows what the world around them was like, clearly labelled as context and not a fact about the person.

Context	Possible sources
Wages and prices, converted to today's money	Bank of England historical data and inflation calculator
Weather and seasons	Met Office Central England Temperature
Maps, buildings and planning	NLS maps, Historic England and Planning Data
Objects and images	Museum collections
How people described life then	Mass Observation, oral histories, diaries and autobiographies
Laws and events	Hansard, legislation and The Gazette

Rules for contemporary accounts

1. **Not representative:** say "people at the time described…" and never "everyone experienced…".

2. **Context, not family fact:** someone else's memories describe the period, not your ancestor's life.
3. **Permission and privacy:** many recordings and writings need permission to publish.

Photo dating aid: using SunCalc, shadows can suggest a time of day or rule out a season, when the photo's location is roughly known. Present it only as a clue.

Life Report and culture links

A single **Write their life story** button produces an illustrated article about a person, with artworks, poems, ballads, folk tales and rhymes from their world placed through the text. Every factual claim links to evidence, and every cultural item is labelled as showing their world, not them.

The Life Report

1. **At a glance:** dates, places and key facts.
2. **Their life in order:** childhood, work, marriage, children, moves and death.
3. **The world around them:** Life and times context.
4. **How artists and writers saw their world:** two or three culture items shown inline, each with a caption explaining why it was chosen.
5. **Sources and gaps:** what's documented, what's inferred and what to look for next.

Users choose a short or long version, edit it before sharing, then publish it, print it or export it as a PDF. Writing it uses credits, so show the cost first.

How culture items are matched

Each artwork, poem, song or story becomes a culture item with:

- **Where:** a real place, or a fictional one linked to it, such as Hardy's "Kennetbridge" for Newbury, possibly Hungerford.
- **When:** the date it was made and the period it shows.
- **What:** Iconclass subject codes, such as harvest, market or soldier, linked to HISCO job codes.
- **Rights:** open, restricted or permission only. This decides whether it's shown, linked or quoted.
- **Why it's relevant:** a short note, written or checked by a curator.

Matching steps

1. Take the person's documented job, places, period and events.
2. Find culture items that match on place, period and subject.

3. Rank by closeness, and prefer openly licensed items.
4. Show the best two or three, each with a "why this was chosen" caption.

Example: for a Berkshire agricultural labourer in the 1850s, the report could include a harvest painting from an open collection, a Victorian ballad about farm work, a rhyme from Halliwell's collection and a short passage from *Jude the Obscure* describing Hardy's version of North Berkshire.

The same system works for famous works about places, such as Blake's poems of London, or an 18th-century painting of Oxford.

Rules

- **Copyright:** quote freely from public domain works such as Blake, Byron, Milton and Hardy. Only link to or describe modern poems, songs and lyrics.
- **Images:** show only openly licensed or permitted images. Otherwise, link to them.
- **Romanticised images:** much rural art made poverty look picturesque, so captions should say "how artists depicted..." and may note the gap between the image and reality.
- **No implied connections:** never suggest the person appears in a work unless there's evidence.
- **No stereotypes:** match on documented details such as job, place and period, not class assumptions.

Data model additions

Object	Purpose	Key fields
`CultureItem`	An artwork, text, song, story or film	Title, creator, type, date made, period shown, places, subjects, rights, source, image or text link
`CultureMatch`	A link between a person and a culture item	Person, item, reasons, score, curator approval
`FictionalPlace`	A fictional place linked to a real one	Name, work, real place, confidence, source
`LifeReport`	A generated report	Person, version, sections, items used, approval, export

Start with: a curated set covering Berkshire, Oxford and rural England from 1750 to 1950, then add tools for historians to tag and suggest matches.

Non-family lineages

A lineage is any chain of things passing from one holder to the next, so the same system can trace pubs, houses, roles, groups and objects as well as families. Start with pubs and houses in Newbury, as they build on the Pigeons research and connect directly to family history.

Type	Examples
Succession	Pub licensees, vicars, mayors, headteachers
Ownership	Owners and tenants of a house, shop or business
Teaching and training	Masters and apprentices, teachers and pupils, academic supervisors
Membership	Regiments, clubs, bands, guilds, unions and churches
Provenance	Heirlooms, paintings, medals, photos and letters
Breeding	Racehorses, dog breeds, and apple or rose varieties
Influence	Recipes, styles, stories and legends
Places and names	Changes of name, use, boundary or street number

Views

- **Succession timeline:** for example, every licensee of the Pigeons as a bar, reusing the Lifeline view.
- **House or business through time:** owners, tenants, uses, photos and maps.
- **Provenance chain:** an object's journey, with gaps clearly marked.
- **Teaching or influence tree:** who learned from whom.
- **Connections:** "this licensee was also your great-grandfather".

Rules: hide recent owners and tenants by default, and show gaps instead of guessing.

Who might pay: clubs, schools, churches and regiments for official histories; pubs and businesses for "history of this place" pages; homeowners for researched house histories; collectors for provenance records.

Record ordering service

When a search finds a record that costs money, ArchiveHub can offer to get it, but only where the provider allows it.

1. A card shows what the record is, who holds it, what it should show, the full price and delivery time.
2. The user pays.
3. ArchiveHub orders it, or passes the request to a partner or researcher.
4. The record arrives in their Archive, linked to the person, and the assistant explains it.

Model	How it works	Best for
Order for the user	ArchiveHub orders and delivers it	Sources whose terms allow third-party orders
Partner reseller	A formal agreement to sell their records	Commercial record sites and larger archives
Referral link	The user buys directly	Sources that don't allow resale
Record agent	A local researcher visits and finds it	Unindexed records, such as workhouse files

Build in: separate provider fee, service fee and VAT; a clear refund policy, as a search may find nothing; careful handling of personal details; and a rights label on each delivered record. Use a payment provider that can act as the seller, and get advice on VAT and consumer refunds.

Check first: official certificates and two or three local archives' copying services, as these are the most likely to allow third-party orders. The GRO index covers births from 1837 to 1934 and deaths from 1837 to 1957, according to GOV.UK.

Data model and architecture changes

Add these objects to the version 1 model. Keep the same rule: every derived item links back to its source, and AI output never becomes a source.

Object	Purpose	Key fields
`DateValue`	Dates that may be exact, approximate or ranges	Earliest, latest, display text, qualifier such as "about" or "before"

Object	Purpose	Key fields
`Residence`	Where a person lived over time	Person, place, address, date range, evidence
`Migration`	A move between places	Person, from, to, date range, evidence
`OverlayEvent`	Wars, laws, local events and personal markers	Type, title, date range, place, visibility, source
`OverlayPreset`	A user's saved toggle settings	User, project, chosen event types
`LifeStory`	A generated life summary	Person, version, linked assertions, approval status
`GalleryItem`	Photo placement and tagging	Media object, people, place, date, order, caption
`ImportJob`	GEDCOM and photo imports	Source site, file, mapping, health report, status
`ExternalId`	IDs from other trees and databases	Object, system, external ID
`MergeProposal`	Suggested matches and merges	Candidates, facts to add, reasons, decision
`ChangeSet`	Bulk edits that can be undone	Changes, user, date, undo status
`Explanation`	A reusable explanation of a term, institution or record type	Term, place, period, text, sources, author, reviewer
`ContextItem`	Life and times entries	Type, place, date range, value, source
`Succession`	Non-family lineage links	Subject, holder, role, start, end, predecessor, evidence
`RecordOrder`	Paid record requests	Record, provider, model, fees, status, rights label

Architecture notes

- **Lifeline component:** use a virtualised list for rows and a single time scale shared with the map. Consider a canvas renderer for very large trees.
- **Timeline and map:** both read from `Residence`, `Migration` and `OverlayEvent`, so updating one updates the other.

- **Places through time:** record each place as it was named and governed at the time of the event, an idea from ex-USSR Kinship Research.
- **Evidence grades:** consider explainable grades such as hypothesis, single source, corroborated, strongly corroborated, contradicted and unresolved, taken from the same repo.
- **Record matching:** learn from the household-based matching in the Irish Genealogy Research Assistant, whose licence is unclear.
- **Shared connectors:** consider sharing one connector layer with Tristero and IntelHub, with different source sets and safety rules.

New data sources

Start with the sources marked **Checked**, where their own pages were read, and treat everything else as a lead whose terms still need confirming. Every source goes into the directory, even if it can't be connected.

Checked sources

Source	What it adds	Terms found
NLS maps via MapTiler	Seamless 1920s–40s OS maps of Great Britain	CC BY 3.0. Free non-commercial use up to 100,000 tiles a month. Commercial use needs a paid plan and NLS confirmation
NLS map collections	220,000+ map images	Rights page not yet read
Historic England Open Data Hub	Listed buildings, conservation areas, monuments and aerial mapping	Open Government Licence
Planning Data	100+ planning and housing datasets for England	Mostly Open Government Licence. Planning applications are still in development
Land Registry Price Paid Data	Home sales since 1995, with repossessions from October 2013	Open Government Licence, subject to data protection law
Bank of England millennium data	Wages, prices and the economy, with GDP from 1086	Open Government Licence

Source	What it adds	Terms found
Central England Temperature	Monthly temperatures from 1659, daily from 1772	Open Government Licence, with credit
The Gazette	Military notices, probate from 1900, insolvency from 1998	Open Government Licence, but personal data isn't covered
The Workhouse website	Workhouses, Poor Law Unions and Poor Law Acts	Private site, so ask permission
Mass Observation	Everyday life from 1937, and from 1981	Reuse terms not stated
IWM Sound Archive	35,000+ recordings, 60,000+ hours	Licensing not shown
Burnett Archive	349 working-class autobiographies, about 1791–1945	Publishing needs permission
Charles Booth's London	1886–1903 poverty notebooks and maps	Reuse terms not stated
Science Museum Group	Collection API and exports	Images often non-commercial
V&A	1 million+ records and an image API	Terms not yet read
Cambridge Alumni Database	Cambridge people, about 1200–1900	Experimental, ask about reuse
British Pathé	Newsreels	Paid licence needed
Wolfram Alpha API	Calculations and general data	2,000 free non-commercial calls a month
The National Archives licensing	Licences to digitise and publish records	Non-exclusive, royalties paid
Ministry of Defence records	About 10 million service records moving to TNA by 2027	Ancestry is digitising parts of them

Leads to check

- **Maps and places:** Geograph, Old Maps Online, OpenStreetMap, Know Your Place, Vision of Britain, council planning portals, GB1900.

- **Explaining records:** GENUKI, British History Online, Leicester Historical Directories, HISCO and inflation calculators.
- **People and events:** GRO index, FreeBMD, parish registers, CWGC, Lives of the First World War, Find a Grave, BillionGraves, Deceased Online, Hansard, Old Bailey and Connected Histories.
- **Government:** probate records, tithe records, the 1910 land valuation, electoral registers, tax lists, coroners and police gazettes, legislation.gov.uk, Find Case Law, BAILII, Companies House, OpenCorporates, the Charity Commission and Electoral Commission data.
- **Economics and environment:** Insolvency Service statistics, ONS, UK Data Service, GBIF, NBN Atlas, BGS, Landsat and Copernicus.
- **Testimony:** BBC People's War, British Library Sounds, Millennium Memory Bank, UK Data Service interviews, Great Diary Project, Domesday Reloaded, Historypin, Europeana 1914–1918, Survey of English Dialects, the Museum of English Rural Life and local oral histories.
- **Film and photos:** Britain from Above, BFI, Wessex Film and Sound Archive, Wikimedia Commons, Library of Congress and Europeana.
- **Museums and broadcasting:** Fitzwilliam, Art UK, IWM, National Railway Museum, Smithsonian, the Met, Rijksmuseum, Art Institute of Chicago, Cleveland Museum, BBC Programme Index, MusicBrainz, Discogs and IMDb.
- **Books and newspapers:** Internet Archive, the Wayback Machine, HathiTrust, Project Gutenberg, Google Books, Chronicling America, Trove, Papers Past, Gallica, Delpher, the German Digital Library, DPLA and GDELT.
- **Education and research:** Archives Hub, school registers, university repositories, OpenAlex, Crossref, Semantic Scholar, arXiv and PubMed.
- **Other:** Wikidata, Pleiades, GeoNames, the Getty vocabularies, Lloyd's Register Heritage, crew lists, railway records, patents, union and company archives, and sports sources.
- **Local partners:** Berkshire Record Office, West Berkshire Museum, Newbury and Reading libraries, the Newbury Weekly News, the Historic Environment Record and local societies.

First five to connect: NLS maps, Historic England, the Workhouse website and GENUKI with permission, the Leicester directories if their terms allow, and The Gazette.

Art, literature, folklore and film sources

These sources feed the Life Report and culture links. Rights vary widely, so store each item's own reuse status.

Art that can be shown in a paid product

Source	What it offers	Reuse found
Yale Center for British Art	British art	Public domain images can be used without permission or fees. Commercial use wasn't addressed on this page
The Met	Open Access images and API	Any purpose, including commercial
Cleveland Museum of Art	64,000+ records and 37,000+ images, with an API and GitHub downloads	CC0, commercial use allowed
Rijksmuseum	Dutch and European art, including everyday life	Mostly public domain or CC0, with CC BY for copyright works
Getty Open Content	160,000+ images, including paintings, prints, maps and 19th-century photos	CC0 images, commercial use allowed
British Library on Flickr	1 million illustrations from 17th–19th century books	Public domain. Captions are limited, so they need tagging
Wikimedia Commons	Images tagged by what they show, where they were made and coordinates	Licences vary. Searchable with SPARQL
Europeana	European cultural items	The API can filter for openly reusable items
Other open collections	Art Institute of Chicago, US National Gallery of Art, MoMA and Smithsonian American Art Museum, listed by a research guide	Mostly CC0, but not checked on the museums' own sites

Data only, or limited images

Source	Restriction
National Gallery	Data CC0 and texts CC BY, but images non-commercial only
Tate	Metadata CC0, but image reuse not covered

Source	Restriction
Art UK	Permissions vary by artwork, and no API mentioned
Government Art Collection	Paid licence needed

Literature and poetry

Source	What it offers	Notes
Project Gutenberg	Public domain texts, including Blake, Byron, Milton and Hardy	Use mirrors for bulk downloads, and follow its trademark and licence rules when reusing texts
Wikisource	Proofread public domain texts	Not checked
Hardy's Wessex	Fictional versions of real places	In *Jude the Obscure*, "Kennetbridge" is Newbury, or possibly Hungerford. "Alfredston" is Wantage, "Aldbrickham" is Reading and "Christminster" is Oxford
Literary Atlas of Wales	Twelve novels mapped to real places	A design model. Data terms unclear
Poetry Archive	10,369 poems, many read by poets	Free to listen to, reuse terms not stated
Wikidata "narrative location"	Where works are set, searchable by place	Not checked

Ballads, folk songs, rhymes and folklore

Source	What it offers	Notes
Bodleian broadside ballads	Nearly 30,000 printed ballads with woodcuts, 16th–20th century	Now in SOLO, with images planned for the end of 2026. Reuse terms not stated
Child Ballads	305 ballads, with 1,216 variants, published 1882–1898	The original is old enough to be public domain, but the site's transcriptions don't state terms

Source	What it offers	Notes
Vaughan Williams Memorial Library	Folk songs, the Roud indexes and the Full English archive	Permission needed beyond private study
Roud Folk Song Index	Index of English-language folk songs	Its own pages weren't reachable
English Broadside Ballad Archive	Early modern ballads and woodcuts	Terms not checked
Nursery Rhymes of England and *Popular Rhymes and Nursery Tales*	Halliwell's Victorian rhyme and tale collections	Public domain texts
Oxfordshire folklore notes	Early 20th-century notes, catalogued by village	Archive material
Folklore Society county surveys	County surveys begun in 1893	Berkshire wasn't in the 1897 allocation
Iconclass	Subject codes for what artworks show	CC0

Film: BFI StoryTrails offers free films linking local stories and archive footage to 15 towns and cities. The wider Britain on Film archive still needs checking.

First to connect: Yale Center for British Art, the Met, Cleveland and Getty, plus Gutenberg, the Child Ballads and Halliwell. Then seek permissions from the Vaughan Williams Memorial Library and the Bodleian.

GitHub repositories found since version 1

These repos are for ideas and, where the licence allows, reuse. Licences come from GitHub's records on 10 November 2026, and the code hasn't been tested. Don't reuse code with no licence or a non-commercial one, and treat GPL and AGPL code with the same care as in version 1.

Timelines, maps and tree views

Repo	What's useful	Licence
Time Travel Map	Timeline slider, alive-count chart and autoplay	GPL-3.0

Repo	What's useful	Licence
Kinwhere	GEDCOM to ancestry map, migration view and research hints	MIT
Family Plot	3D tree positioned by birth year, with photos and GEDCOM	GPL-3.0
TreeMonk	Infinite investigation board, historic maps and timelines	Non-commercial only
family-chart	Editable tree built on D3	MIT
dTree	Trees with multiple parents, built on D3	MIT
js_family_tree	Interactive tree using d3-dag	GPL-3.0
GEDCOM SVG fan chart	Fan charts from GEDCOM	MIT
SVG Timeline Genealogy	Genealogy timelines in SVG	No licence
GedcomGraph	Tree layouts on top of GEDCOM	GPL-3.0
Tam-VR	Exploring a tree in virtual reality	No licence
3D fan chart	A GEDCOM fan chart as a 3D object	No licence

AI research agents

Repo	What's useful	Licence
ex-USSR Kinship Research	Evidence grades, historical places and name variants	MIT
autoresearch-genealogy	Research prompts and templates from a nine-generation project	MIT
genealogy-mcp	MCP server that knows 171 archives and gives links and plans	MIT
Irish Genealogy Research Assistant	Record-linkage scores and household-based conflict resolution	Unclear
Open-Genealogy	Prompts based on the genealogical proof standard	CC BY-NC-SA, non-commercial

Repo	What's useful	Licence
gramps-mcp	AI assistant tools for a Gramps tree	AGPL-3.0
Family Tree Kit	Agent-built trees where every fact needs a document	MIT
Kinprove research recipes	Fact-checked recipes for DNA and record searches	Unclear
Strom Research	AI parish register research	AGPL-3.0
AncestryLLM	Local, private tools for GEDCOM and RootsMagic	MIT

Archives, documents and record linkage

Repo	What's useful	Licence
Betty	Encyclopedia-style family history websites	GPL-3.0
Family Book	Private, self-hosted family tree and archive	MIT
WarisanAI	Family archive with stories, photos and timelines	MIT
Yugraphy	AI that reads printed family books	Unclear
FamilyLore	Reads handwritten family letters	MIT
genealogy_ai	Extracts details from documents with OCR and AI	MIT
Metric books transcriber	Transcribes handwritten register images	Unclear
Record linkage examples	Machine learning for matching records	Unlicense
US census linkage list	Links to census linkage projects	No licence

Non-family lineages

Repo	What it traces	Licence
Chinese kinship calculator	The correct term for any relative	MIT
Xiangsheng Genealogy	Master-to-apprentice performance lineages in 3D	MIT
Joseon exam explorer	84,525 people who passed Korean civil service exams	MIT

Repo	What it traces	Licence
European dynasties	Royal and noble marriages	MIT
Wikidata tree generator	Trees of historical figures	MIT
Western Australian BMD matcher	Matching an official index to Wikidata	No licence
Bible study vault	4,427 linked people and places	MIT

Ideas to borrow

1. Explainable evidence grades.
2. Places recorded as they were at the time.
3. Autoplay through time.
4. Household-based record matching.
5. A brick-wall investigation board.

Strategy, rights and cautions

Don't compete with Ancestry on record volume. ArchiveHub should make sense of everyone's records, by helping people use the big sites, building what they lack and partnering locally first.

Strategy

- **History first:** broader research can be built on the same tools, but the product stays centred on people, places and the past.
- **Data path:** guide people to existing sites, import their research, partner with local archives on non-exclusive terms, then pursue licences from The National Archives and others once there's revenue.
- **Public memory bank:** an optional, consent-based modern Mass Observation built from users' interviews, which they can withdraw.
- **Shared infrastructure:** consider one connector layer for ArchiveHub, Tristero and IntelHub.

Cautions

Risk	Rule
Living people	Hide by default in timelines, house histories, exports and public pages

Risk	Rule
Context mistaken for fact	Label historical context, interpretations and contemporary accounts clearly
Bulk tree errors	Show reasons and conflicts, and allow one-step undo
Copyright and licences	Store each source's terms with its records, and avoid copying beyond what's allowed
Downloaded records	Keep private by default, as many licences cover personal use only
Paid record orders	Follow provider terms, show all fees and explain refunds
DNA	Leave until much later, with specialist advice
Location and property data	Never offer a people-search feature

The legal checks from version 1 still apply, and a lawyer should review data licences, contributor terms, payments and privacy before launch.

New work packages

These follow version 1's WP1 foundation and WP2 research core. The Lifeline view comes straight after, so the headline feature is built early. Timings are rough estimates for a small team.

WP9: Lifeline view and migration map (about 4–6 weeks)

- [ ] `DateValue`, `Residence`, `Migration`, `OverlayEvent` and `OverlayPreset` tables.
- [ ] Virtualised rows, a shared time scale, the year slider and the alive-count chart.
- [ ] Event layers, toggles and custom markers.
- [ ] Linked map with migration paths and autoplay.
- [ ] Chat commands, export and phone layout.

- **Done when:** all six Lifeline acceptance tests pass.

WP10: Imports and tree tools (about 4–5 weeks)

- [ ] GEDCOM 5.5 and 7 import, with source IDs kept.
- [ ] Tree health check, merge preview, change sets and safe deletion.
- [ ] Photo-folder import with suggested matches.

- **Done when:** a real exported tree imports cleanly and its problems are listed.

WP11: Life Story and galleries (about 3–4 weeks)

- [ ] Life Story pages built from assertions.
- [ ] Person and family galleries, snippets and source cards.
- **Done when:** a test user prefers it to the equivalent Ancestry page.

WP12: Explain this record and Life and times (about 4–6 weeks)

- [ ] Explanation and context tables, plus contributor credit.
- [ ] Starter explanations for Berkshire and Poor Law records.
- [ ] Context connectors for prices, weather and maps.
- **Done when:** a workhouse record shows all four layers with sources.

WP13: Lineages and record ordering (about 3–5 weeks)

- [ ] Succession table and timelines, starting with Newbury pubs.
- [ ] Record order cards and statuses, starting with one permitted provider.
- **Done when:** the Pigeons licensees show as a timeline, and one test record can be ordered.

WP14: Life Report and culture links (about 4–6 weeks)

- [ ] `CultureItem`, `CultureMatch`, `FictionalPlace` and `LifeReport` tables, with rights on every item.
- [ ] Connectors for Yale Center for British Art, the Met, Cleveland and Getty.
- [ ] Public domain text imports from Gutenberg mirrors, the Child Ballads and Halliwell.
- [ ] Iconclass and HISCO tagging, plus a curator review queue.
- [ ] The Life Report builder, with inline images, quotes, captions, editing and PDF export.
- **Done when:** a sample Berkshire labourer's report shows at least three correctly licensed culture items, each with a reason, and no item is shown without the rights to do so.

Starter prompt for VS Code

```
Read docs/SPEC.md and docs/UPDATE-1.md. UPDATE-1 takes priority where they
disagree. Build WP9, the Lifeline view, only. First propose the data models,
components and any new dependencies with their licences. Then build in small
commits with tests, using fake family data. Don't reuse code from GPL, AGPL,
non-commercial or unlicensed repos. When finished, report which acceptance
tests pass and what still needs checking.
```

Sources

The main pages opened for this update are linked in its tables. Key ones:

- The National Archives: licensing partners
- The National Archives: MoD service records
- GOV.UK: research family history
- Ancestry: uploading and downloading trees
- FamilySearch: download your family tree
- Planning Data quickstart
- Mass Observation
- The Met: image and data resources
- Getty Open Content
- Bodleian: broadside ballads
- Vaughan Williams Memorial Library: licensing